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Crafts Council of India

A Symposium on

The Future of Handmade

Chettinad

TamilNadu

1st February 2026

The Crafts Council of India

The Crafts Council of India is a registered Society (NGO) founded in 1964 by Smt. Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay. It works to promote and support Indian artisans and craft clusters through education, design and marketing initiatives. From its fledgling roots, the organization has grown into a credible entity, with 12 affiliated Councils.

The Future of handmade

The theme of the Symposium is the Future of the handmade sector, with India being gifted with the widest and largest repository of living practitioners. India thus also has the responsibility to inform a global path. Globally it is often accepted that there are around two billion people from indigenous, rural and economically underdeveloped sections of society that compose the cultural and creative production sector all over the world.

As the global threat of climate change increases, it is bringing increased recognition to the sector as a means of climate mitigating production, carrying centuries worth of traditional knowledge within it, as we also rise in the need for sustainable consumption. Is this enough to encourage a Renaissance? How should India be gearing up for the 21st C?

Topics of Discussions:

Panel 1- Entrepreneurship Curriculums for Gen Z creative producers.

Exploring the changing dynamics of digital technologies, consumer shifts and challenges of second- and first-generation artisan entrepreneurs as they access new knowledge tools and fast evolving systems. Strengthening the supply side of creative, handmade practices for a vibrant future.

Panel 2 - Co- Creating a Public Good, Platform www.handmade.world.

Accelerating the role of organized, real data in the sector, through the creation and evolution of a Public Good Platform, societal in nature, co-created by producers, craft networks, creative institutions, professionals, the private sector and government.

Panel 3 - Crafts in the Climate Change Discussion, Mitigation and Resilience building.

Globally jobless growth is being witnessed, and AI will bring more changes. In this context the world of creative, handmade practices holds a unique position under the topic of sustainability which includes both environmental and social sustainability, with India needing to become a global leader in discussions. This is a critical demand-side lens, as it will have critical impact on markets of the future.

Panelist - 1

Toolika Gupta

Director, Indian Institute of Craft and Design, (IICD) Jaipur

Dr Gupta is an educator in the field of Craft education, her focus is on design, material culture, Indian knowledge and value systems, market linkages and research in these areas. Skill building, facilitating young artisan wards to get into higher education which promotes the culture of crafts and sustainable living is her passion. She is also the President of Alliance Francaise de Jaipir and chairperson of the Textiles and Clothing Research Centre in Delhi.

Her expertise lies in

- Research in Material culture, in culture history in story telling using crafts
- Management of the craft institute
- Research in material culture especially clothing and textiles
- Incubation of craft start ups
- Outreach and skilling
- Story telling using crafts



Panelist - 2

Latha Tummuru

Program Lead, Creative Enterprise Lab, Creative Dignity, Mumbai & Hyderabad

Latha Tummuru is an apparel and textile designer with over thirty years of experience working with handloom weavers and craft practitioners. She is a trustee and working member of Dastkar Andhra and a visiting faculty at premier design institutes in India. Since 2023, she has led the Creative Enterprise Lab at Creative Dignity, strengthening artisan enterprises nationwide.

Her key areas of work include clothing and textile design as well as teaching craft & textiles at design institutions like NID & IDC School of Design. Her expertise lies in creating new markets for handmade products through enterprise development programs for artisan entrepreneurs.



Panelist – 3

Nishit Sangomla

Director at Somaiya Kala Vidya, Kutch, Gujarat.

Somaiya Kala Vidhya, is an institute of education for traditional artisans. In 2020, he co-founded another organisation – Navikarana Trust, which works with the communities at the forefront of climate change in the Himalayan region by providing them with access to water and resources. Nishit has acted as a mentor for multiple micro-entrepreneurs, fellowship programs and incubators.



Panelist – 4

Jishnu Prasanna – Artisan

Creative Director, Bhavm, Center for traditional Kerala Murals and Handicrafts. Wayanad, Kerala

Jishnu is a creative professional engaged in the preservation and contemporary adaptation of traditional crafts. Work focuses on integrating indigenous materials with sustainable design practices to develop culturally rooted, market-oriented products. Through research, design intervention, and entrepreneurship, contributes to craft revival, skill development, and cultural sustainability.

His expertise lies in

- Traditional crafts & sustainable design
- Cultural entrepreneurship, product development, and craft revival



Panelist – 5

Khatri Nuaman Farid Ahmed – Artisan

Craft person of Bandhani, Gujrat.

Nuaman Khatri is an artisan designer from Bhadli Kutch, belonging to a family of Bandhani craftspeople. Growing up within the craft, he developed a deep, hands-on understanding of Bandhani traditions. A graduate of Somaiya Kala Vidyalaya, he works to position Bandhani as a contemporary craft practice. He is a recipient of the Digital Artisan of India Award 2025, honouring his contribution to craft and artisan-led design.

His expertise lies in bandhani textile, craft-based design development, and artisan collaboration.



Panelist - 6

Neelam Chhiber

Co- Founder, Industree, Goa.

Neelam has devoted the last 40 years into building an understanding of the creative and cultural production eco system in India and globally. An Industrial designer from National Institute of Design, she has been recognised as a Social Innovator, by the World Economic Forum network as well as the Economic Times in India. She has retired, whilst Industree continues to flourish.

Industree's work enabled the evolution of the 6C Ecosystem, essential for growth of artisanal enterprises. Construct, Capacity strengthens the supply side. Create, Channel define the demand side whilst connect and capital enables to exponential scale.



Panelist - 7

Akshatha Narayana

Strategy lead - Buildings and Intersections at Rainmatter Foundation, Bengaluru, Karnataka.

Akshatha Narayana is an architect and climate strategist at the Rainmatter Foundation, working across two focus areas: Built environment and Place-Based Approach. She leads efforts to make India's construction sector sustainable and resilient through vernacular and low-carbon building systems, and supports shaping regionally grounded climate strategies that connect ecological thinking with practical, on-ground action where ownership and solution infrastructure are two key important levers.

Her expertise lies in

- Place-based and bioregional climate action
- Sustainable habitats for resilience
- Informal and traditional construction ecosystems & workforce transitions
- Climate communication, art, and participatory design



Panelist - 8

Kanchan Ganorkar

Enterprise Platforms, CIO Function, Mumbai.

Kanchan Ganorkar heads the Enterprise Platforms portfolio in the CIO Organization delivering solutions for Wipro Employees. Her current mandate includes rapid development tools, process automation as well as service management for the enterprise at large. She carries expertise in strategic initiatives with a keen focus on process engineering, value creation and customer experience.

Her expertise lies in core Implementation, Digital Transformation, Process Engineering, Automation, Channels, Data Solutions, Enterprise Platforms.



Panelist - 9

Nitin Pamnani

FOUNDER, ITOKRI.COM, GWALIOR.

Nitin Pamnani is the co-founder of iTokri, a leading handmade and craft-focused e-commerce platform in India. With deep roots in grassroots retail and digital strategy, he brings together storytelling, technology, and sustainability to shape meaningful commerce. Nitin works closely with artisans and teams to build systems that are both scalable and empathetic. He believes in hands-on, founder-led growth.

His expertise lies in digital strategy for e-commerce, performance marketing, GTM & analytics, D2C growth operations, technology implementation, marketplace integrations, customer lifecycle & CRM, and artisan supply chain systems. Nitin brings a deep, hands-on understanding of how to scale purpose-driven digital businesses, with a focus on founder-led marketing, empathy-driven UX, and full-funnel tracking.



Panelist - 10

Sudha Shivakumar

Vice President of Crafts Council of India, Chennai

Sudha Shivkumar is a lawyer and an investment banker by profession. Her prolific career spans over 45 years and includes leading large organizations and mutual funds, managing international portfolios, spearheading non-profit ventures, all while keenly mentoring and inspiring women from all walks of life.

She is the Director of her family's business in manufacture of Auto ancillaries. She was actively involved with the World Craft Council in its projects, 'Abhushan' and 'Kaivalam'. She was the National President of Ficci Ladies Organisation for the year 2023 - 2024, headquartered in Delhi. Focused strategic planning, penchant for process improvement and the ability to inspire teams to reach higher goals are her inherent skills.



Panelist - 11

Abhishek Jain

Green Economy and Impact Innovations at the Council on Energy, Environment and Water, New Delhi.

He built and continues to oversee the Council's practices on Sustainable Livelihoods, Sustainable Food Systems, Tech and AI, and Energy Access. He advises senior leaders on various policy and impact issues at the intersection of economics, equity and environment.



Panelist - 12

Meera Goradia

Chair, Creative Dignity. Mumbai

Meera Goradia is a leader at Creative Dignity, shaping strategy and partnerships to strengthen artisan livelihoods. She leads Craft x Climate, linking traditional craft knowledge with climate action, and drives handmade.world, a global initiative building shared narratives, collaboration, and visibility for the handmade ecosystem. Her work centres on regenerative, inclusive systems where artisans are equal stakeholders in sustainable futures.

Her expertise lies in

- Craft-led climate action and regenerative systems
- Network building and collaborations in the handmade ecosystem
- Narrative building, advocacy, and global visibility for craft and artisans



Agenda:

Sunday -1st Feb

Venue – VS Madam, Kanadukathan

10am- 10.05am **Welcome by Visalakshi Ramaswamy Chairperson of CCI**

10.05am-10.10am **Setting the Overview for the Day – Neelam Chhiber**

10.15am-11.30am **Panel 1- Entrepreneurship Curriculums for Gen Z creative producers**

- Latha Tumuru, Project Lead, Creative Dignity
- Nishit Sangomla- Soumaya Kala Vidya
- Jishnu LR - Artisan
- Khatri Noumen Farid Ahemad - Artisan

Moderator - Toolika Gupta – Director, Indian Institute of Crafts and Design

11.45am -1pm **Panel 2 – Co- Creating a Public Good, Platform** www.handmade.world

- Nitin Panmani, Founder, ITokri, Co-Chair, Creative Dignity
- Kanchan Ganorkar, Head - Business Platforms, CIO Organization, Wipro Ltd.
- Akshatha Narayana- Rainmatter Foundation

Moderator - Neelam Chhiber, Co-founder, Industree.

1pm -2.30pm **LUNCH**

2.30pm -3.45pm **Panel 3 - Crafts in the Climate Change Discussion, Mitigation and Resilience building**

- Meera Goradia, Chairperson, Creative Dignity
- Abhishek Jain, Council on Energy, Environment and Water, Fellow and Director, Powering Livelihoods
- Akshatha Narayana- Rainmatter Foundation

Moderator- Sudha Shivakumar, Vice- President, Crafts Council of India

3.45pm Vote of Thanks by Malavika Phadke Secretary CCI

3.50pm Tea